

# Communication Breakdown

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The year was 1996. It was a cloudy afternoon in Ogden, Utah, the wind was blowing and the air was brisk. Seven-year-old, nearly officially Mormon me, hopped off the school bus and began walking up the hill towards home with plans to head straight into my chilly and windy backyard to light up my very first cigarette—mere feet away from my family, and with no lighter or matches, mind you.

The sky was angry that day, my friends. Like an old Mormon trying to return tickets to a matinee. I remember walking up the steep incline of the hill towards the house, the anticipation in the air that something was afoot was palatable. There was a fisheye lens look to the world and I remember feeling as if I could float away like a cloud because of my puffy grey and blue coat. I floated up the hill, feeling as if it was just me in the world. I went inside for a moment, put my bag down, and then headed straight for the backyard to have my fated fag. Sorry, back then it still just meant cigarette, or bundle of sticks, so get over yourself for a minute, I'm telling a story.

Anyway, next thing I knew my parents were holding the cigarette box, and I was sitting in a corner in trouble until they knew what to do with me. What on Earth was going through my head that I thought smoking was a good idea, and who gave them to me, they inquired. Mom distraught, dad furious, caught up in the swell of their own emotions, they couldn't hear me saying, "I found them in the backyard just now and brought them to you." A flat out lie, the reader assumes, and you'd be correct if you were my parents, because this is the story they attempted to make me believe about myself my entire life; to which I always fervently, and truthfully denied.

What actually happened was, all of that description about hopping off the bus, the look and feel of the day while walking up the hill, going outside to play when I got home almost immediately, that is all true, but when I went into the backyard, just as I was getting on the swing set, I noticed a box of cigarettes in the mid-tall grass. Curiously, I remember it only had one missing, which surely didn't help my case; the case of a seven-year-old with busy, tired, emotional, untrusting parents; making me wonder what was going on in their lives and minds back then, and if Ben Folds was right when he said,

"It seems to me if you can't trust, you can't be trusted."<sup>1</sup>

I remember attempting to answer the question of "who did you get them from," in the form of, "I found them in the backyard, and I think they are from the back neighbors." The neighbors to the west had a backyard that was thick with oak trees and poison ivy, and it was probably a good thirty feet or so from our fence line before reaching their back patio where they would drink and smoke while hanging out in their hot tub. The most little me could figure and assume, having been taught that smoking was bad and difficult to quit, was that the neighbor back there had had their last one, throwing it away in the hopes

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<sup>1</sup> Folds, Ben., "Trusted," *Songs for Silverman.*, Sony, Epic., 25 Apr. 2005.

to never smoke again—an admittedly thin attempt to make a cigarette box careen through a thicket of trees. In hindsight, however, part of me wishes that this attempt at an excused explanation would have triggered in my parents the thought I had many years later, not thinking as an obedient, innocent, seven-year-old Mormon, that it was likely one of the troublesome, older, neighbor kids to the north, out defying *their* Mormon parents instead, having had their own first cigarette, tossing it over the fence so that they didn't get caught. I'm almost certain the swing set was on that side of the yard then anyhow, where we eventually kept the trampoline, and not its more typical south-westerly location.

For the rest of my formative years with my immediate family, whenever the story would come up, it was always made out to be that I had made an attempt to smoke, and was being a disobedient, lying child. But then why would I eventually come clean about burning down Granddad's camping trailer when I was six, but stick to my smoking guns on this?

Now, exactly when this next moment in the story happened currently escapes me. It was not something I wrote down. It was one of those moments that was so thoroughly stark and apparent that it could never again be questioned; memory-burn as the proverbial *they* say. Perhaps there is something to that, as during the event I became flush, and by the end I couldn't tell if I was sweating, or merely on the cusp—as if always walking through a wind when no wind is present on a crisp, crepuscular 62 degree evening in early October. Though the dates escape me now. I have more than an inkling and a slight edge on the rational side of reason to believe that the fractal of time and its geographical memory bank in the crooked bow of my hippocampus occurred on approximately the same date, and at the same time. Either way, it was, on both occasions, late Fall.

I had been spending hours a day for months meditating and I was making discoveries I personally found valuable—almost as if I had been preparing for this moment. While I had been able to overcome this personal hurdle, I continued to wonder what exactly was the cause of my inability to properly communicate what I'm thinking and how I'm feeling to those who need to know what's going on with me the most. During any moment of crisis in the years before 2019 those things which became overwhelming and difficult to discuss with my parents simply caused me to shut down, not know what to say, or not want to say anything at all. I'm sure the fibro-fog stress triggers did not help. This communication breakdown, it was always the same; I'd be having a nervous breakdown that would drive me insane, and there were times my face went numb from the intensity of the experience, but even when I had something that I thought the other person oughta know, I'd drive it to ruin. All of this unfortunately, yet inevitably, transferred into other areas and relationships in my life.

I was in my laundry room, it had to be mid-day, somewhere between 3 and 4 PM. I had just transferred a load of laundry to the dryer and was preparing the next wash. It was exactly as I felt on that day as a child about to be intellectually and emotionally smoked out by his parents, feeling as if I could float away on the wind, or as if I could walk through a wind when no wind is present. A curious and light feeling, inundated in the natural and spontaneous emergence of Wumen's kōan,

“Let subject and object be so *oned* that the wind cannot pass between them.”<sup>2</sup>

I remember reaching for the bottle of detergent when I began to wonder, with a deep desire to understand this part of me, what held back my communication skills for so long. I was standing there with a mixture of self-disappointment that I hadn’t communicated better sooner, but was also glad that I had since figured it out. It’s not about communication actually, it’s about comprehension of communication in its various presentations. I started the wash and turned around to start folding some of the warm towels that had just come out of the dryer. I grabbed a hand towel and began folding when I heard a large gust of wind outside. I opened the window right next to me to check on my very old Alaskan Malamute who often liked to sleep on that side of the house, and to check the stability of the unstable west fence. I looked down and out to see my fluffy husky boy there sleeping peacefully nearby, enjoying the cold air; I loved that dog so much, and he meditated with me often. Out of the corner of my eye I spotted something white in the grass. I looked north into the yard as another gust of wind came through, carrying with it an opaque grey fog with the slightest hint of a lavender hue. This fog passed through the yard and over my entire field of view, and as it cleared away I saw a mighty handsome young boy, about seven years old, walk over to the white object in the grass, pick it up, examine it for a moment, and then turn around, walking toward my back door. I walked out of the laundry room and across the kitchen to the back door and opened it up. There was no little boy, but out there, in that north-west patch of yard, (where a swing set might as well have been), was that small white object in the grass. I went to pick it up to find that it was just a thin piece of styrofoam padding that had likely escaped a package when the recycling truck had come by that morning. It was the size and shape of a cigarette box.

In this moment I knew that is when and where it all started. My inability to communicate my thoughts, feelings, behaviors, and actions, they were stifled that day in the Fall of 1996. My parents simply didn’t believe me, and never did. I was taught then and there that a bent truth was more often believable than the truth of the matter itself, so why not lie all the time anyway? The truth was always a lie, so lying was the truth. The truth is a crooked tale.

This inability to communicate often carried over in humorous ways. In the summer of 2005 I had taken to participating in musical theatre, but did not bother telling my family that I had several solos and some prominent parts in the upcoming performances. They all arrived to see the show, expecting me to be in the back with the ensemble, having no idea that I could even sing well enough for my own showcase. This left them wondering why I would keep such a thing, such talent from them. Discomforts in communication run deep.

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<sup>2</sup> Wumen, The Gateless Gate, 1228